

COLORADO RARE BIRD REPORT

Red 2/2/01 wpl

SHARP-TAILED SANDPIPERCalidris acuminataLocation: John Martin Reservoir, Bent County, ColoradoDate: October 4, 2000

This bird was discovered on October 3rd by Van Truan. It was also seen by many other Colorado birders, including Brandon Percival the day before, and Duane Nelson, Ric Olsen, Norm Erthal, Joey Kellner, Dick Schottler, with me on the 4th. I am not sure of inclusive dates, but I believe it wasn't seen after October 7th.

This is a low, muddy marsh drainage above John Martin Reservoir. There are open muddy and semi-flooded flats, surrounded by grassy and reedy edges. The area was full of shorebirds, including Long-billed Dowitchers, Pectoral Sandpipers, Baird's Sandpipers, Stilt Sandpipers, *Pluvialis* sp. plovers, and peeps of various species. I arrived on October 4th at 7:10 a.m. at the spot and almost immediately found the bird in my scope. This bird was not real flighty. At one point, a passing car scared off all birds save the Sharp-tailed. I did see it fly short distances twice. In flight it looked like a Pectoral Sandpiper. I heard it call twice. It walked on the open mud for about 15 minutes, then worked towards the edges and walked in and out of the grassy margins of the mudflats. I observed the birds with sun, then high clouds, from distances of 25-75 yards for about an hour, until 8:00 a.m. I used my B & L 10x40 Elites, and my Kowa TSN-4 scope.

Description:

It was a juvenile. The bird was similar in size, shape and attitude to the Pectoral Sandpipers, but did not particularly associate with them. The bird was pretty much a loner. The bird was a largish, plump calidrid. It was structurally much like a Pectoral Sandpiper but with a shorter neck and a very slightly shorter bill. The legs were a little less yellow than Pectoral. The bill was medium-length, slightly and evenly down-curved, and pale-based. The legs were medium-long and dull yellow. The bird was overall quite bright, with rufous and orange tones. The breast was rich, buffy tan, with fine, weak, dark streaks across the upper breast. The orangish tones to the breast gradually gave way to the white underparts. There were fine, long, black pencil-line like streaks on the white undertail coverts, especially at the sides. The cap was a reddish, chestnut color and there was a very distinct white superciliary broadening behind the eye. The face showed a chestnut-brown cheek patch and a thin, but distinct white eyering. The back was brown with pale whitish lines at the scapulars. The flight feathers were broadly chestnut fringed.

Similar Species:

Size and shape rule out most other sandpiper except Pectoral, Red Knot, Stilt Sandpiper. Red Knot (and dowitchers) have dark legs. Dowitchers have much longer bill. Red Knot is plumper, plainer, different bill. Peeps smaller, plainer, lacking pale-based bill. Pectoral Sandpiper similar only in structure (though note differences above). Pectoral lacks chestnut crown, has weaker eyering, lacks chestnut ear patch, has brownish, heavily streaked breast with a sharp line between dark and light below. Pectoral has unstreaked undertail coverts.

Experience with Species:

This is my first Sharp-tailed Sandpipers, though have seen other similar calidrids.

This report was prepared from notes made during and immediately after observation.

Mark Janos
10 Sedum Ct.
Pueblo, CO 81001

